appearing epigraphic messages that has ensured the continuing scholarly interest in Ashoka.

Certainly, this was the assessment of the colonial scholar-civil servant Vincent Smith when he wrote *Asoka—The Buddhist Emperor of India*.[44] As the first modern biography of the emperor, this book strove to tell a historical story strongly on the basis of the emperor's words. Its core was devoted to the history and chronology of Ashoka, the extent of his empire, the way in which it was administered, the monuments that Ashoka built, and the epigraphs. Smith also provided translations of and subheadings to each of the edicts. So, for instance, the Thirteenth or Kalinga Rock Edict, where the war and Ashoka's repentance were described, was given the title 'True Conquest'. Textual traditions, those of Sri Lanka and India, too found a place even in Smith's book, though the author made his opinion of them clear at the outset. They were, he said, 'of no historical value, and should be treated simply as edifying romances.'[45] He was of the firm conviction that no king East or West could match Ashoka, the only ruler to combine in himself the duties of a monk and a monarch. Coming from Vincent Smith, an administrator of imperial inclinations and views, such unambiguous approval was a refreshing surprise: most of Smith's writings were known for their sweeping generalization that the stimulus of all ancient Indian high culture lay in the West.[46] Realizing that the obvious comparison would be with the Roman emperor Constantine, Smith quickly dismissed it for the reason that Constantine's patronage of Christianity was 'an act of tardy and politic submission to a force already irresistible, than the willing devotion of an enthusiastic believer.' Ashoka, on the other hand, transformed the creed of a local sect which had 'captured his heart and intellect' into a world religion.[47]

Smith's book set the tone for many subsequent works on Ashoka in the sense that epigraphic sources became the inevitable and desirable guide when depicting him. The emphasis tended to depend upon the scholar, the